

ANIME

Japan Sinks: 2020

★★★★★ | Modern disaster features often leave a bad taste in your mouth. Especially with the stale, recycled “Dwayne Johnson saves the world” concept. So, going into Netflix’s latest anime series, we were a bit sceptical. Little did we know that the so-called disaster feature that we signed up for, would turn out to be an emotional roller coaster.

Directed by Masaaki Yuasa, Japan Sinks: 2020 follows the story of the Mutoh family. An ordinary family of four, who are put to the test, when a series of earthquakes wreak havoc across Japan. The first thing that stands out about this anime is its unique art style and animation. All the characters have weird anatomies and wacky animations, where either their appendages look too big and wobbly or their facial expressions look



absurd. But instead of taking away from the immersion, it adds to the rawness. The hand-painted backgrounds, on the other hand, follows the standard anime aesthetic and looks spectacular.

The pacing of the story is quite decent, standing at a mere 10 episodes of about 25 minutes each. It manages to create a state of panic and terror like no other via its raw and graphic presentation.

From emergency alarms blaring through cellphones to people getting squished beneath structures, it is a package of pure anxiety. Despite being advertised as a disaster show, its prime focus is human relationships. And it takes time building those, by sticking to one particular family and the people they encounter. Every character in this anime has a distinct personality. They are all easy to connect with and root for, as their pain, hardships and emotional turmoil are reciprocated exceptionally. The show also does an outstanding job of constantly toying with the audience’s minds, by shifting between emotional themes unpredictably. One moment you see a ray of hope and the next thing you know, it throws a devastatingly shocking curveball, leaving you with a feeling of utter despair.

Overall, Japan Sinks: 2020 fares really well in terms of quality storytelling and emotional (shock) value. Unless you are a stickler for a particular art style, its only negative aspect would be the occasional derailing from the main plot. As long as you can get past that, it is a solid anime that is definitely worth your time.

TV SHOW

JU-ON: Origins

★★★★★ | When it comes down to cold and ominous horror, nobody does it better than Japanese media. Takashi Shimizu’s Ju-On films, in particular, with its “vengeful spirit” concept. Its latest adaptation is a Netflix Originals series that stays true to the source material.

Directed by Sho Miyake, Ju-On: Origins follows the story of Yasuo Odajima (Yoshiyoshi Arakawa), a paranormal researcher who is approached by Haruka Honjo (Yuina Kuroshima), an actress who had been experiencing ghostly incidents. While unravelling the mystery behind the events, the series transcends through time and tells multiple horrifying stories. Each involving individuals, who are all somehow, connected to a certain haunted house. This show demands your



utmost attention as it is rich in lore and details that tie the story together. Structure wise, it feels confusing and randomly woven at first. But as the story progresses, the connections start taking shape. The show’s pacing is great and concise. With six, 30-minute episodes, it manages to keep you intrigued by making each episode darker and more spine-chilling than the last. Every episode ends on an anxiety-inducing cliffhanger which is

followed up by shocking revelations. The show does not shy away from extremities and showcases instances of sex, rape, domestic violence and gore on full display. You also bear witness to some petrifying imageries that build up quite the fear and intensity. To the point where you are forced to pause the playback and take a break now and then.

The performance delivered by the actors is nothing short of exceptional. Their fear, pain and trauma are reflected seamlessly onto the audience. The cinematography, editing and sound-work are also top-notch. It makes use of some dynamic camera angles and lighting that pulls you right into the ominous atmosphere, which is further aided by the intense soundtrack. Especially the glorious ending theme, gawd dayum!

The fear factor in Ju-On: Origins might not be everyone’s cup of tea. But, it has got an incredibly dark and unsettling story, which builds up subtly and gradually gets intense and captivating. Overall, a binge-worthy horror masterpiece that has been a long time coming.